



*The ILL Clan crew improvise the dialogues for their award-winning Machinima movie, **Hardly Workin'***

actors' approach to Machinima". Dellario explains further: "Its major disadvantage, to me, is the lack of a real-time camera recording feature, without which Machinima loses its major advantage as a commercial production medium."

Does *DOOM III*, to be launched from the much-worshipped id Software stable, get the juices flowing? Hancock says, "Drool. I can't wait. If I had to place a bet on which package would blow the Machinima scene wide open and cause it to explode into the film world, I'd have my money on *DOOM III*." Dellario couldn't agree more: "It's amazing and when it comes out next year, I predict it will be a watershed moment for the Machinima community."



*Frank Dellario,
President, ILL
Clan*

“Because we shoot in real-time, in a 3D virtual environment, we're combining the fast pace of a film shoot with the flexibility”

Not just because of the amazing physics or the attention put on increasing the level of quality, but because of the dynamic lighting ability. Now, a character carrying a flashlight or a lantern for example, will affect the lighting in the environment. This may sound small but it's not. Lighting in any film is one of the major story-telling and artistic tools at a filmmaker's disposal."

The hardware driving this phenomenon is not forgotten, nVidia's next-generation GPU, the NV30 for example, is expected to use 64 and 128-bit colour rendering, delivering accuracy greater than that of *Toy Story 2*. Dellario thinks that the new hardware will advance the ability to create Machinima, letting it compete more closely with what Hollywood creates using large (read expensive)

rendering farms. "Programmable GPUs are where Machinima will get an extra boost. They represent a blank canvas to the teams that create tools for Machinima, allowing them to explore real-time approaches to traditional filmmaking techniques such as wipe, transitions, etc. But more importantly, it will allow them to develop unique approaches that will visually create scenes that are otherwise nearly impossible—real-time or not." The fact that these solutions will take them closer to what pre-rendering currently offers is what gets Hancock excited: "Obviously, the only impact they will have is visually, but that impact will be massive. Certainly, the GPU advances happening at the moment are one of the main things closing the gap between real-time and pre-rendered solutions."

Reinventing the reel

So, what does the future hold for this exciting film-creation technique? Will Machinima, like its mentor, the gaming industry, inundate itself into the cloning vat, merrily stuck in the groove of unoriginality?

"I don't think it's old enough or settled enough to be stuck in a rut at this time," counters Hancock. "Machinima is an astonishingly young art form: we've scarcely even managed to figure out the basics of Machinima creation yet, much less scratched the surface of its possibilities. Over the past 12 months, I've seen people working on Machinima projects ranging from sci-fi epics to abstract pieces, from ultra-real thriller projects to sketch rendered music videos. Machinima at the moment is startling in its diversity, and that's only increasing as users get more familiar with the medium." Dellario ruminates on the query and offers a historical perspective: "There was a lot of activity early on, but that flurry of excitement got buried by reality. It still takes time, blood, sweat and tears to make a film, regardless of what medium you use. A lot of the original community were teenage gamers who've since moved on or lost interest. Now we're in the stage of making this into a legitimate process in the animation community."

To spark a revolution, a concept has to pass this litmus test: it should be cost-effective and it should not force a drastic re-learning of the tools and techniques involved. Machinima seems poised to usher in a new era of animation and film-creation. Will it pass the test and deliver? As a viable alternative to traditional animation, it has already made some inroads into the gaming sector, although it has a long journey ahead. As an art form, let us hope that budding filmmakers discover this tool—the Machinima Film Festival 2002 was recently held to award just such pioneers. The question then is—**is Machinima your calling?**

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